

Designs on Border

Following LEW's South African interlude and the subsequent French connection, it's now the turn of a fashionable exchange with Pakistan Fashion Week (PFW). As part of the South Asia Exchange Programme, designers from across the border will take to the ramp to showcase collections from the upcoming PFW slated to start from November 5. While garments from 12 designers will tread the fashion floorboards, only a handful of names like Hassan Shehryar, Sonya Batulla, Nickie Nina and Nomi Ansari will personally attend, owing not to delayed deadlines and fashion disasters but visa problems. Thanks to red tape and bureaucratic bungles, even the organisers are not sure of how many designers will finally turn up for the showcase. Here's to some cross-border couture confusion.

FOREIGN HAND: Shehryar with his creations

important," he says.

Ironically, Chopra's corner has faced flak for launching an international model hunt and signing on seven catwalk sirens from Dubai. Says a catty Indian model left waiting in the wings, "When you talk big about promoting Indian fashion, you should automatically also promote Indian models, and not bring in *firang* girls to walk the ramp in Indian clothes." Defending the move, Chopra says, "Our motto is to integrate Indian design with global fashion and this

is a two-way process. Just as Indian designers get exposure overseas, international labels come to India. When you become a platform catering to the domestic and international market, there are times when foreign buyers would like the look or statement but be confused about how it



ANUPAMA DAYAL: Multi-ethnic meets techno in *The Oracle*. Geometric prints, inspired by vintage weaves, are seen on dresses and skirts.

would look on their consumers. Hence, the idea was to work with a good mix of Indian and international models."

With a battery of debuting designers ready to storm the runway in the GenNext category and promising emerging names like Nimita Rathod and Nachiket Barve taking to the ramp, LEW remains a hotbed for talent-spotting. Wendell Rodricks has further heightened the excitement quotient by turning stylist for the highly anticipated GenNext show. But one can't ignore the fact that multiple shows by the same established handful might not be the best trend take. Both Mukherjee and Narendra Kumar Ahmed are poised to take two curtain calls. Mercifully, Neeta Lulla has cancelled her Gini & Jony-sponsored outing, only to be quickly replaced by Rocky S.

With a host of sponsored shows by Gitanjali Lifestyle, Freedom Fashions by Gini & Jony, Levis, Allen Solly and Portico in the offing, LEW runs the risk of becoming more of a trade show than a formidable fashion frontier. And even as fashion watchers catch the last fashion week of the calendar year, they are keeping their trendy fingers and toes crossed, hoping that this spring-summer sojourn will throw up a few pleasant surprises.

